Chapter 20: Meet in Secret. Make Plans.

“I’ve never seen anything like it,” York complained as he sat around a table with half the counsel, Emmar from Aschelle, Ulf from Phyrn, and Awshin from Alfir.

Awshin sniffed the air before speaking. He looked rather odd, as he had dog ears, a dog snout, and a dog tail, due to being part cu-sith. “No one is listening in,” he announced. “I can smell anyone, so Calix is not here, and no one is hiding. We can talk freely. We need to stop Erik and Catria.”

“Agreed,” Emmar stated. “Aschelle should rule, and Terrian will have the power to overthrow us when Erik and Catria get on the same field. We can’t let them take the field together.”

“They could stop the war,” York pointed out. “If the war stops, all of us lose power.”

“I’m fine with the war stopping,” Emmar countered, “as long as it stops with Aschelle ruling all the cities.”

“Not Phyrn,” Ulf insisted. “We are controlled by no other city.”

“Try to control Alfir,” Awshin barked. “Even the leaders of Alfir can’t control it.”

“Alfir needs control!” Emmar argued. “Maybe I should have my war mages attack yours to take over your city.” He then looked at York and asked, “Would you allow us to fight to take over a city? Carlin would not, but you are making several changes.”

York thought for a moment and decided, “It would have to be team on team and the defending team would be allowed to fight past gems going dark where the attacking couldn’t. Could you beat Alfir that way?”

“Perhaps,” Emmar answered, “but I’m thinking Terrian.”

York smiled, “I will allow it on a trial basis. If Aschelle takes over Terrian, that will reign Catria and Erik in.”

Awshin laughed. “After Aschelle attacks Terrian, we want to fight the winner for control of both cities.”

“No,” York insisted. “Only one such battle would be appropriate in a day, as it’s only fair to have both teams be fresh.”

Awshin shrugged. “Then we can take over Phyrn.”

“Never!” Ulf seethed back. “We are stronger than Faeborn, We could beat you, particularly if we are allowed to fight past our gems going dark. Phyrnians

don’t let pain stop us. We do not give up!”

“Faeborn aren’t afraid of you,” Awshin snipped back. “The only reason we haven’t taken Phyrn or Aschelle over is that we don’t want either of them. Faeborn don’t want to be part of the human world.”

“Alfir is chaotic,” York noted. “I won’t be surprised if there are faeborn involved in the thefts.” He smiled. “Of course, they do keep the battles going.” He the glared at Awshin and accused, “So many faeborn are thieves.”

“It’s not wrong to steal from lesser races,” Awshin argued. “Might makes right.”

“True,” York agreed, very calmly. “In the arena, it definitely does. Now, does anyone know how we can keep Terrian from winning every fight? I fear what will happen when Catria and Erik are on the same team. The two alone could put a stop to the war.”

“We are going to take over Terrian,” Emmar assured him. “Perhaps we need to cause enough trouble that Erik and Catria have to put there wedding off.” He leaned over the table and asked, “Awshin, Ulf, are you with me?”

“If it pays,” Awshin answered.

“On condition you arrange for me to get Xena back,” Ulf answered. A wry smile crossed his face. “I could use to get whoever shot at Erik and went through his shielding to help.” He looked at Awshin. “That has to be a faeborn.”

Awshin shook his head. “I know of no race of faeborn

who can get through a magical shield. Perhaps it's a war mage skill someone hides."

York shrugged. "It would be nice to know, but it would be dangerous for that person. Perhaps what we need is invisibility."

"That's pretty rare," Awshin explained, "But Calix has helped, for a price."

York tapped his fingers for a moment, then decided, "We really need a plan."

Ulf nodded. "Slayde and the thieving ring will help. I'm sure Aiden the Invincible will too, as it's him who, Slayde steals for. Calix helps already, and many faeborn can be hired. I had a part-sprite rob someone for me for a three whistling arrowheads."

Emmar chuckled. "We'll find a way. Terrian will soon be ours."

Chapter 21: Get Married. Celebrate.

Friday after battle day, a large crowd gathered for Catria and Erik's wedding, as there were large numbers of guests from both Terrian and Cruia. After all, both Catria and Erik were both war mages, and Catria's father ran her province. So many people came, even though the wedding had been moved up a week because there were more attempts against Catria, and Erik wanted her better protected.

The wedding was outside due to so many people from Terrian and Cruia wanting to come. That made security a nightmare. After all, so many people were afraid of Erik and Catria and obviously wanted them dead.

Yet, other people were worrying about keeping unwanteds out. Catria and Erik got to focus on the wedding.

Catria excitedly dressed in a long, flowing blue dress, fixed her hair, and waited for the ceremony to begin.

The wedding was beautiful. Catria's father walked her

down the aisle, and Dillion was Erik's best man. King Hamill of Terrian performed the wedding himself.

"This is a marriage I am happy to seal," King Hamill announced as he gave a speech about marriage. "Erik and Catria, the two of you are very good for each other. Everyone can feel the love between the two of you, and everyone can see your goodness. Both of you have a light that shines brightly, blessing all those around you. Never before have I married two war mages with unicorn, and I expect greatness from each of you. By that, I mean that I expect each of you to fully commit to each other, to your family, your future children. I expect both of you to help build community and peace. You are both icons to the people. Be the examples people need."

He said more, but Catria had a hard time focusing on his words. After all, she was standing with Erik, holding his hands and looking into his eyes, the reality of them getting married hitting. The smile on her face shone, and a white light shimmered all over her. Erik was finally hers.

She heard King Hamill ask, "Catria, do you take Erik to be your husband and promise to love and support him through whatever life hands to you?"

The shimmer of light grew so people could see it as her smile burst larger and she answered, "I do. I definitely do."

King Hamill then asked, "Erik, do you take Catria to be your wife and promise to love her, provide for her, and

protect her, no matter how hard life is?”

Erik looked deep into Catria’s eyes as he answered, “I do.”

“Then I now pronounce you man and wife,” King Hamill announced. “Erik, you may kiss your bride.”

Erik eagerly kissed Catria to the cheers of the crowd, and the couple walked down the aisle to music playing.

There was a grand reception, not an expensive one, but very large.

People brought food that was put out on tables, and everything sparkled, mostly due to a few faeborn who came begging to help decorate as they loved weddings.

Erik and Catria served themselves some food and ate it when they had breaks in people congratulating them. Then they went to dance.

Everyone seemed to be having a very good time, at least until some faeborn put fairy wine in the punch. Then some chaotic things began to happen. Some people were speaking in rhyme, some couldn’t stop dancing. One man sang everything he said, another started acting like a puppy.

“I’ll get them to undo the effects,” Hrod assured Erik and Catria. “You two just enjoy your night.” He shook his head as he walked off.

Erik and Catria did ignore the problems, focusing their attention on each other. After all, nothing else mattered to them except that they had just been married.

Not only did they not notice some of the silly antics, they didn't notice there were some with much more dangerous intent.

York and most of the counsel was in attendance. Erik and Catria hadn't really invited most of them, but York insisted that with such a major wedding of two war mages from different teams, both with unicorn, that the counsel should be there.

York walked around with a smile plastered on his face. He approached Erik's mother, congratulated her and noted, "Two war mages with unicorn is unusual. Them marrying is even moreso. Would you have guessed this from him when he was younger? Was he the standard type of boy who would defy his parents, steal small things, or bully other children?"

Erik's mother looked at him with some confusion and simply answered, "No. He's always been very respectful and good to everyone. He was always the type to step between the bully and his victim, not bully anyone."

"How noble," York responded trying to hide his disappointment. "You must be proud."

"I am," Erik's mother confirmed. "Now, excuse me. I wish to go mingle with more guests."

As York talked with family and friends of Erik's, Emmar, the councilman from Aschelle, talked with people who knew Catria.

He only found one person who didn't only have glowing remarks about her, and that was a man named

Stephen who said he had courted Catria and she broke his heart.

Yet, when Emmar asked about it, he found Catria had done nothing cruel but merely refused Stephen's proposal thinking them not a good match.

He was frustrated when he met back up with York. "I can get nothing on either of them," he complained.

"Indeed," York replied. "I would expect everyone to have some wrong-doings in their past. It's normal, but no one will admit to Erik and Catria having any." With furrowed eyebrows, he thought for a moment before concluding, "This is their wedding. No one who has dirt on them would come."

"I don't think there is dirt," Emmar admitted. "Perhaps there is a reason both of them saw a unicorn. It's pretty obvious with their power that they did."

"We need dirt on them," York quickly responded. "If we can't dig some up, perhaps we need to create some."

Emmar smiled. "Every man has his weaknesses. I think we need to find Erik's."

"Indeed," York agreed.

A bell rang, and everyone was called together to witness Erik and Catria kiss over the cake and cut it.

Cheers rang from the crowd as they did, and people started singing a song that was tradition in Terrian. As soon as it was over, musicians began playing again, and everyone started dancing a Cruian style dance.

The mix of Terrian and Cruian traditions made for an exciting night, and Erik and Catria were entirely unaware of any intrigues.

Hrod wasn't. He had stopped a Phyrnian from trying to put poison in Erik's cup, and was very concerned about questions York and Emmar were asking.

He walked up to Rhys and asked, "Do you think York is going to try something tonight?"

"No," Rhys answered. "York doesn't do anything to cast suspicion on himself. He'll have someone else do his dirty work, and tonight would be a horrible time to bring any accusation up. Everyone will think it horrible to accuse a newly married couple of anything."

Hrod nodded and replied, "True."

Rhys laughed back.

"What's funny?" Hrod asked.

Rhys answered, "After tonight, it's all your problem. I am moving to Cruia and joining their war mage team and you will be the captain of team Terrian."

"Are you sure I should be captain?" Hrod asked. "Sean would be good."

"You are the right man for the job," Rhys noted. "Take good care of Catria."

"I always do," Hrod replied, looking over at Catria with great emotion.

"This must be hard for you," Rhys noted. "I know

you like her. You just never admitted it."

"She always has just seen me as a brother," Hrod pointed out. "I've accepted her as my little sister and gave up on more years ago. I just want her happy. I think Erik is good for her." He smiled. "Besides, I've taken a liking to a maiden named Elizabeth. I'd go ask her to dance, but I have to watch for trouble."

"I'll get Sean to watch for you," Rhys assured him. "Go asked the girl to dance."

Hrod eagerly walked over to a beautiful redhead and asked, "Would you like to dance?"

She blushed and answered, "You are Hrod. You are a war mage, a very strong and handsome one, and you want to dance with me?"

"Indeed," Hrod responded. He held his hand out to her. "Will you?"

"Of course," she agreed as she took his hand.

The two went and danced. Everything was about to change. He was about to be captain of team Terrian, Rhys was moving to Cruia. Erik was joining the team, and Erik and Catria were huge targets. Yet, he would protect Catria. She was his team member and like a sister.

Hrod then looked at Elizabeth. Worrying about problems could wait. He had a pretty maiden to dance with. For a while, he wouldn't worry about anything.

Ironically, right then a man came running through the field they were dancing in meowing, while several

maidens, barking like dogs, chased him.

After a moment, they man stopped and smiled. The maidens tackled him to the ground.

The man didn't seem to mind, but Hrod told Elizabeth, "I'm sorry. I think I need to go stop some out of control faeborn and throw the punch out."

"I'll come with you," Elizabeth offered. "It will be exciting."

The two went to deal with that. As they did, another man from the crowd started singing:

"Oh, I'm a fool, I dance and sing.
My head's not full of anything.
Now, watch my stunts. I do them well.
You'll see great talents. I excel."

He then picked up several full mugs and tried to juggle them. He couldn't juggle and really made a mess, but the people around laughed, knowing faeborn had come.

"This is going to be quite the night," Hrod noted. "Let's hope faeborn are the least of our troubles."